Chiara Motta

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Education

University of California, Berkeley Expected May 2027
Ph.D. in Business and Public Policy, Haas School of Business

Bocconi University 2019
M.Sc. in Economic and Social Sciences, *summa cum laude*

Bocconi University 2016
B.Sc. in Economics and Social Sciences, *summa cum laude*

University of British Columbia 2015
Visiting Student

Fields

Labor Economics, Spatial Economics, Industrial Organization

Job Market Paper

"Can Place-Based Subsidies Improve Labor Market Efficiency?" (with Federico Cingano) [Draft]

Place-based subsidies are often targeted to firms in distressed regions on the premise that local labor is underutilized. This paper studies how wage-setting institutions shape the incidence and efficiency of a large investment subsidy program in Italy. Funding was allocated to firms based on rankings and fixed budgets, which we exploit at two levels: a regression discontinuity across participating firms, and a recentered instrument across labor markets. Combining application records, longitudinal firm data, and matched employer–employee data, we show that funded firms expand employment by 13% without raising average wages or upgrading workforce composition. Incumbent workers benefit primarily through additional weeks of employment, especially those with weaker labor market attachment, while wage gains are concentrated among workers earning above their contractual floors. We find no evidence of competitor firms increasing wages in the same labor market, and no detectable in-migration. Together, these findings suggest that contractual minimums bind for most workers, yielding employment rationing. While the subsidies alleviate the underemployment generated by rationing, the program's cost still outweighs its estimated social benefits.

Working Papers

"The Cost of Buying American," with Matilde Bombardini, Andres Gonzalez-Lira, and Bingjing Li. *Revise & Resubmit, American Economic Review* [Draft]

The latest resurgence in the U.S. of policies aimed at reducing imports and bolstering domestic production has included the expansion of Buy American provisions. While some of these are new and untested, in this paper we evaluate the employment and welfare impact of long-standing procurement limitations on the purchase of foreign products by the U.S. Federal Government. Employing procurement micro-data, we calibrate a quantitative trade model adapted to include features relevant to the Buy American Act: a government sector, policy barriers in final and intermediate goods, labor force participation, and external economies of scale. We show that current Buy American restrictions on final goods create about 100,000 jobs at a welfare cost of about $170,000 per job. The imminent tightening of domestic-content rules for inputs to 75% creates about 86,600 jobs at a welfare cost of about $119,000 per job. We also find scant evidence of the use of Buy American rules as an effective industrial policy tool.

"*It is Never too Late*," with Filippo Palomba [Draft] [Slides]

Can technology relax constraints on educational supply and expand local productive capacity? We exploit a quasi-natural experiment in postwar Italy to estimate the causal impact of educational television on adult skills and local economic activity. In 1960, the Italian public broadcaster and the Ministry of Education expanded televised adult education, with *Non è mai troppo tardi* ("It Is Never Too Late") as a flagship program—a daily literacy course supported by a national network of collective viewing centers designed to broaden access. We digitize historical records of transmitter locations and technical characteristics to predict television reception and link these predictions to industrial- and population-census data. Our effects are identified from variation in signal diffraction caused by topography, conditional on transmitter placement. We estimate stacked long differences across the 1951, 1961, and 1971 censuses for roughly

7,700 municipalities. A one-standard-deviation increase in signal strength raised adult literacy by 0.18 percentage points during the program decade relative to the preceding decade—17% of the average decadal gain. It also increased labor-force participation by 1.0 percentage point overall and 1.4 percentage points among women, and shifted employment out of agriculture. Labor-market outcomes responded to reception in neighboring municipalities within approximately 15 kilometers, consistent with local spillovers. Estimated literacy gains were larger in initially less literate municipalities and in places with collective viewing centers. Our findings suggest that broadcast technology can expand educational provision and support structural transformation, with benefits extending across municipal boundaries.

"The Labor Market Effects of Competition: Evidence from the Hudson's Bay Company," with Lukas Leucht and Davis Kedrosky [Slides]

Outside options are central to models of wage determination, but the alternatives available to workers are rarely observed directly. We study the Hudson's Bay Company (HBC), a chartered trading monopoly whose dominance in the Hudson Bay basin was challenged by the expansion of the North West Company. We digitize over a century of HBC account books, which value furs received from Indigenous trappers and goods paid in exchange in a common unit, and reconstruct the locations, ownership, and operating dates of recorded trading posts. Together, these sources allow us to measure trappers' compensation relative to the company's valuation of their output and trace how it changed as rival buyers came within reach. We find that trappers received approximately two thirds of the HBC's Standard valuation before 1770 and nearly all of it by the 1790s. Most of this increase occurred within existing posts. With post and decade fixed effects, a rival within 500 kilometers was associated with a 4.4 percentage point higher share, while proximity to other HBC posts showed no comparable association. A calibrated spatial oligopsony model connects trading terms to the geography and ownership of alternative posts and accounts for part of the observed increase.

Selected Work in Progress

"Monopsony Power Across Firms," with Sydnee Caldwell, Ingrid Haegele, and Joerg Heining

"On-the-Job Training in the Age of AI", with Jinci Liu and Dominik Wehr

"Product and Labor Market Power: Evidence from Firm-to-Firm Networks," with Eugenia Menaguale

Teaching Experience

Microeconomics (EWMBA 201A), UC Berkeley Haas (Evening/Weekend MBA) — Fall 2024, 2025, 2026

Student evaluations, overall effectiveness: 6.83/7 and 6.56/7 (EWMBA core average: 6.02)

Cheit Award for Excellence in Teaching (2026) - best GSI of the Evening & Weekend MBA program, Haas School of Business

Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor Award (2026) - UC Berkeley, given to about 10% of GSIs campus-wide

Berkeley Business Academy for Youth, guest lecture, UC Berkeley Haas — Fall 2024

Microeconomics; Markets, Organizations and Incentives, Bocconi University — 2019–2020

Macroeconomics; Macroeconomics I – Global Scenarios, Bocconi University — 2019–2020

Research & Professional Experience

Graduate Student Researcher, UC Berkeley — 2021–2024

Visiting Researcher, Structural Economic Analysis Directorate, Bank of Italy — 2022, 2025

Pre-doctoral Researcher, Bocconi University — 2019–2020

Economics Intern, Competition and Markets Authority — 2018

Summer Intern, European Commission (DG Competition) — 2017

Honors, Fellowships, & Grants

Fisher Center Research Grant — 2026

University of California President's Lindau Nobel Meetings Fellow — 2025

Opportunity Lab Place-Based Policy Initiative — 2024, 2025

Spiller PhD Fellowship; Simpson ABD Fellowship in Global, International and Area Studies — 2025

UC Berkeley IRLE Social Sciences Research Pathways; UCB Student Opportunity Fund — 2025

Visiting Scholar Program, Italian Social Security Institute (INPS) — 2024

Berkeley Economists for Equity Research Grant; Williamson PhD Fellowship Fund — 2023

Price Theory Summer Camp, Becker Friedman Institute, University of Chicago	2023
University of California, Berkeley Scholarship	2020–2025
Marco Fanno Scholarship, UniCredit Foundation	2020–2022
Bank of Italy: Research Fellowship; *Donato Menichella* Scholarship (outstanding distinction)	2022; 2020
IGIER Visiting Student, Bocconi University	2017–2018

Conferences & Presentations

2026 Urban Economics Association North American Meeting (Chicago; also discussant), All California Labor Economics Conference, Innsbruck Faculty Research Seminar, O-Lab Applied Microeconomics Conference on Economic Opportunity, Berkeley Labor Symposium (spring and fall*), Oliver E. Williamson Seminar, Berkeley Labor Lunch, Berkeley Trade Lunch, Berkeley Labor Seminar*, New Thinking in Industrial Policy: Perspectives from Developed and Developing Countries (Columbia University)*

2025 Berkeley Labor Lunch, Berkeley Trade Lunch, OEW Student Seminar, AIEL Workshop on Labour Market Policies, Lindau Nobel Laureates Meeting, OpportunityLab Research Workshop

2024 OEW Student Seminar, Bocconi CLEAN Workshop

2023 IO Workshop, Economic History Workshop, OEW Student Seminar, Bocconi CLEAN Workshop

2022 OEW Student Seminar, Bocconi CLEAN Workshop

* *scheduled*

Service & Other

Mentor: *Social Science Research Pathways*, *Mentoring Women in Economics*, *Lead The Future*, Berkeley *URAP*

Programming: Stata, R, Python, LaTeX | Languages: Italian (native), English (fluent), French (basic)

Last updated: October 24, 2026